

Pahankanuwa Sermon #8

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

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(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

Phandanaṃ capalaṃ cittaṃ,

durakkhaṃ dunnivārayaṃ;

Ujumaṃ karoti medhāvī,

usukārova tejanaṃ.

Vārijoṇaṃ thale khitto,

okaṃ katarābhato;

Pariphandatidaṃ cittaṃ,

māradheyyaṃ pahātave.

From:

Verse 33 and 34 from the Cittavagga (Chapter on the Mind) of the Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

Today, this Poya day is conventionally referred to as the 'Ada Vesak' (Half-Vesak) Poya. Even the mere mention of the word 'Vesak' is sufficient to arouse a deep strength of faith (*saddhā*) in devout Buddhists towards the Buddha, his life, and his immense store of virtues. We all know that what we call a Buddha is a spiritual friend (*kalyāṇa-mitta*) who points out the path to Nibbāna at a time when beings in this *saṃsāra*, having burned for an extremely long time in this *saṃsāric* suffering (*dukkha* / unsatisfactoriness / stress), oppression, and

fire, direct their minds toward [real] life. The Buddha himself has declared himself to be a spiritual friend to the world.

With the appearance of a Buddha, we are afforded the opportunity to receive instructions that reveal this path to Nibbāna. Now, what is called *saṃsāra* is a journey akin to travelling in a circle. When one tries to escape from this circle—to direct the mind toward that noble state of deliverance called escape (*nissaraṇa*) or Nibbāna—the mind, accustomed to the momentum of running in this circle, does not listen. Because of *saṃsāric* habits, this is no easy task.

Considering the past, this is like an attempt to escape from the kingdom of Māra, to break free from it. It is like the effort made to escape from the kingdom of Māra after having been his subjects for an exceedingly long time. This is something that must be done with extremely intense effort and exertion. If one enters upon this task thinking it is an easy one, they will very quickly have to retreat. Therefore, the person who hopes to realize Nibbāna, who is preparing to strive for the realization of Nibbāna, must first gain some understanding of the *saṃsāric* weaknesses, the deceptive states (*vañcaka dhamma*), and the obstacles of Māra that may arise in one's mind. It is the Buddha who reveals this matter to us. The Buddha is indeed that greatest and most noble being, the spiritual friend (*kalyāṇa-mitta*), who can give us timely advice regarding the obstacles that may arise in this journey to Nibbāna.

Now, the two verses we have taken as our theme demonstrate the weaknesses, deceptive states, and forces of Māra that generally hold sway in the mind of a *saṃsāric* being. Just as these verses provide some understanding of these things, they also contain guidance on how they can be overcome, along with helpful instructions. The introductory story (*nidāna kathā*) that occasioned the preaching of these verses is as follows:

On one occasion, the Buddha was residing on the Cālīka mountain. At that time, a venerable monk named Meghiya was serving as his attendant. One day, Venerable Meghiya approached the Buddha and asked permission to go for alms to the nearby village of Jantu. The Buddha granted permission. Thereupon, Venerable Meghiya took his bowl and double-robe, entered the village for alms, and after his alms-round, was walking up and down on the bank of the Kimikālā river. In the meantime, he saw a highly beautiful mango grove nearby. Seeing it, he thought, "Ah! This mango grove is sufficient for a son of a noble family preparing to strive for Nibbāna. This is the best place. I must obtain permission from the Blessed One and come here to meditate."

Later, in the evening, he visited the Buddha, and said to him: "Venerable Sir, when I went to the village of Jantu for alms today, I saw a place like this. It

occurred to me that this is quite sufficient for a son of a noble family to arouse energy for Nibbāna. It is a good place, a delightful place. If the Blessed One grants me permission, I would like to go to that place to meditate." Then the Buddha said: "Meghiya, I am alone at this moment. Wait a little until another monk arrives." But Venerable Meghiya did not comply. Once again, he said to the Blessed One: "Venerable Sir, you have nothing more to do. Everything has been completed by you. Furthermore, there is nothing new to be added to the state you have attained. As for me, I still have much work ahead. To attain Nibbāna, I have many things to do by way of meditation to add to what I have done. Therefore, if the Blessed One permits me, I shall go."

For the second time, the Blessed One said: "Meghiya, I am alone at this moment. Wait until another monk arrives." Yet, he did not comply. For the third time, he pleaded, saying that the Blessed One has nothing more to do, but that he has work to do. "Therefore, if the Blessed One permits me..."—here the word *padhāna* is used. *Padhāna* means intense exertion/striving. "If you permit me to apply *padhāna* exertion for meditation, I shall go there." At that moment, the Buddha neutrally remarked: "Well, Meghiya, if you say you are going to apply *padhāna* exertion, what can we say? Then, do as you wish." Thus the Buddha gave permission "neutrally."

So, Venerable Meghiya went to the said mango grove with great expectations and determination. Having gone there, he prepared a seat in a good spot under a fine mango tree, and sat down for meditation. But despite sitting down for meditation, from the very moment he sat down, streams of thoughts (*vitakka*) started flooding his mind—unwholesome thoughts: thoughts of sensual desire (*kāma-vitakka*), thoughts of ill-will (*byāpāda-vitakka*), and thoughts of cruelty (*vihiṃsā-vitakka*). As you, devout practitioners, know, these are the opposites of Right Intention (*sammā-saṅkappa*) in the Noble Eightfold Path—wrong thoughts (*micchā-saṅkappa*): thoughts of sensual desire, ill-will, and cruelty. These came flooding into his mind. He tried to meditate the entire evening. He could not unify his mind. He could not collect it. Instantly, a great sense of urgency (*saṃvega*) arose in him: "Alas, I am one who went forth into homelessness with great faith (*saddhā*). Isn't it a great wonder that such thoughts still flood my mind?" Then, in the evening, he returned to the Buddha and said: "Venerable Sir, I went there and sat down for meditation. From the moment I sat down, grand thoughts of sensual desire, ill-will, and cruelty have been flooding in." At that moment, the Buddha delivered a very valuable sermon: "Meghiya, if a person's concentration (*samādhi*) is not strong, not mature, there are five things, five factors, that help to mature that concentration, to bring it to maturity. What are those five factors?"

"What is the first factor? It is when a monk has a good spiritual friend (*kalyāṇa-mitta*), possessing the blessing of a spiritual friend. That is the first factor: having a spiritual friend. What is the second factor? A monk is complete in the virtue (*sīla*) appropriate to him. That is, he protects his training rules properly, seeing danger in the slightest faults, training himself in accordance with the training rules, and maintaining discipline. He has perfected his virtue. What is meant there is being virtuous. Next, what is the third factor? That monk gets the opportunity to hear Dhamma discussions conducive to Nibbāna, bringing thoughts of Nibbāna, which are called the ten subjects of talk (*dasa-kathāvatthu*). What are the ten subjects of talk shown in the Dhamma? Here, the Buddha lists them one by one: talk on wanting little (*appicchatā-kathā*), talk on contentment (*santutṭhi-kathā*), talk on seclusion (*paviveka-kathā*), talk on aloofness/dissociation (*asaṃsagga-kathā*), talk on arousing energy (*viriyārambha-kathā*), talk on virtue (*sīla-kathā*), talk on concentration (*samādhi-kathā*), talk on wisdom (*paññā-kathā*), talk on deliverance (*vimutti-kathā*), and talk on the knowledge and vision of deliverance (*vimutti-ñāṇadassana-kathā*). These are the ten subjects of talk."

If we understand them briefly: talk on wanting little (*appicchatā-kathā*) means talks about having few desires. Here, "talks," dear practitioners, refers to things heard during a sermon or a Dhamma discussion. Suppose that monk gets to hear a Dhamma discussion or a sermon where his spiritual friends (*kalyāṇa-mitta*) explain the benefits of having few desires—this is *appicchatā-kathā*. Next, talk on contentment (*santutṭhi-kathā*) means talks on being satisfied with what one has. Talk on seclusion (*paviveka-kathā*) means talks about living in deep seclusion and its value—its benefits. Next, talk on aloofness/dissociation (*asaṃsagga-kathā*) means separating oneself from crowds, leaving the herd. As you, dear practitioners, know, if you look at wild buffaloes or other animals, they have a tendency to move in herds. Generally, even humans have made it a habit to live in herds. To live without the herd, without crowds, is a great science to many; that is why it is called *asaṃsagga-kathā*. It is the value of living while protecting the mind from the herd and the currents that come with the herd—*asaṃsagga*—meaning the benefits of living without association with crowds. Next, talk on arousing energy (*viriyārambha-kathā*) means talk on arousing effort—the benefits of putting forth effort and arousing energy to burn away defilements, to draw wholesome qualities near, and to remove unwholesome qualities. What follows is understood by the words themselves. Talk on virtue (*sīla-kathā*) means talks on virtue. Talk on concentration (*samādhi-kathā*) means talks on concentration. Talk on wisdom (*paññā-kathā*) means talks on wisdom. Talk on deliverance (*vimutti-kathā*) means talks on Nibbāna. Talk on the knowledge and vision of deliverance (*vimutti-ñāṇadassana-kathā*) means

talks on the knowledges related to Nibbāna. In this way, getting the opportunity to hear matters regarding the ten subjects of talk is a valuable gain for a monk to prepare his mind. Next, it is said: making use of that, what is the fourth factor? A monk applies himself to the task of removing unwholesome thoughts and drawing near wholesome qualities with intense energy, relentless energy, and energetic exertion. This is called aroused energy (*ārabdha-viriya*). That is the fourth factor. What is the fifth factor? A monk possesses the deep insight-knowledge that sees arising and passing away, or what is called *udayabbaya*—that is, a deep understanding of the impermanent / inconstant (*anicca*) nature of the world. He becomes one who has a penetrating wisdom that constantly sees arising and passing away.

These five factors are highly helpful for a person to prepare their mind before going to meditate. What are the five factors? If we mention them briefly: a monk—though we say "monk," dear practitioners, you can understand this as applying even to any meditating practitioner (*yogāvacara*)—has a spiritual friend (*kalyāṇa-mitta*). "Friend" is not used in the ordinary social sense—as you, dear practitioners, know, a spiritual friend in the Dispensation is not someone who merely puts an arm around your shoulder. In society, a "friend" or "companion" is someone with whom one associates in good or bad times. That is not what is meant by "spiritual friend" here; that is not why the word is used. When the Buddha speaks of a *kalyāṇa-mitta*, we can understand how deep a word this "friend"—*kalyāṇa-mitta*—is. He is a teacher whom one must worship, respect, and from whom one must receive advice. Therefore, the first factor mentioned here is association with a teacher. The second factor is being virtuous in the virtue (*sīla*) appropriate to oneself. The third factor is the ten subjects of talk in that manner. Just as described for the Saṅgha, it is the opportunity for lay practitioners as well to hear Dhamma discussions, Dhamma talks, sermons, etc., regarding Nibbāna and relating to Nibbāna, to help their meditation. Next, the fourth factor is applying effort, intense effort, unwavering effort on one's own part in accordance with that. The fifth factor is one's own power of wisdom (*paññā*): applying well-established mindfulness (*sati*) and wisdom to engage in the task. These five factors are fundamental and primary for anyone embarking on the work of Nibbāna with deep intention.

Having said this, the Buddha declared: "Meghiya, one who has brought their concentration to maturity with the support of these five qualities, these five factors, must next develop four meditations. What are they? Here they are shown: Foulness (*asubha*) must be developed for the abandoning of lust (*rāga*). As you, dear practitioners, know, the meditation on foulness is practiced to free the mind from lust (*rāga*)—the attachment that is a grave defilement carried along for a long time in *saṃsāra*. Next, loving-kindness (*mettā*) must

be developed for the removal of ill-will (*byāpāda*), which means hatred and anger. Now you know that with these two, the Buddha has declared the medicine for both attachment and aversion. Next, thirdly—as the third meditation—mindfulness of breathing (*ānāpānasati*) must be developed. Mindfulness of breathing (*ānāpānasati*), which is the establishing of mindfulness on inhalation and exhalation, must be developed. Its purpose, the main objective, is the cutting off of thoughts (*vitakkupaccheda*). Applying the mind to one's inhalation and exhalation helps to cut off thoughts. Generally, when thoughts come flooding, one does not even remember that one is breathing. Yet, when one directs the mind, even with difficulty, to this subtle process, thoughts find no room. That is why it was declared that mindfulness of breathing is especially helpful for cutting off thoughts. Next, what is the fourth meditation shown? The Buddha has enjoined: 'Develop the perception of the impermanent / inconstant (*anicca*).' Keep the perception of the impermanent / inconstant (*anicca*) constantly present. That helps to eradicate the conceit 'I am' (*asmimāna*). The deep conceit called *asmimāna*, which lies beneath the ordinary pride, arrogance, and haughtiness of the world, is the extremely subtle part: the conceit 'I am' (*asmi*). The perception of the impermanent / inconstant (*anicca*) helps to remove that."

In this manner, the Buddha taught four meditations. Having declared this, he explained to Venerable Meghiya the connection between them, and showed the reason for presenting them so. There, the perception of the impermanent / inconstant (*anicca*) was given as the meditation. He shows how, through the perception of the impermanent / inconstant (*anicca*) itself, one can proceed to Nibbāna. "Meghiya, in one who has the perception of the impermanent / inconstant (*anicca*), the perception of not-self / non-self / unsubstantial (*anattā*) becomes established. One who has the perception of not-self / non-self / unsubstantial (*anattā*) removes the conceit 'I am' (*asmimāna*)—the subtle conceit 'I am'—and in this very life (*diṭṭhe va dhamme*), in this world, right here, attains that calming of all *saṃsāric* suffering (*dukkha* / unsatisfactoriness / stress), that extinguishment, the noble state of Nibbāna." Having declared so, he uttered two verses as joyful utterances (*udāna gāthā*) at that moment. Those are not the verses we took as our theme earlier, but were spoken in addition to them. The Buddha spoke two verses there demonstrating the pressure caused to a person by thoughts and his own freedom from them.

Khuddā vitakkā sukhumā vitakkā,

Anugatā manaso uppilāvā,

Ete avidvā manaso vitakke,

Hurāhuraṃ dhāvati bhantacitto.

That means: minor thoughts, subtle thoughts—*khuddā vitakkā, sukhumā vitakkā, anugatā manaso uppilāvā*—thoughts that float on the mind, arising from within the mind itself. These thoughts—*ete avidvā*—the ignorant person, not knowing these thoughts arising in the mind—*manaso vitakke*—*hurāhuraṃ dhāvati bhantacitto*—becomes exhausted, bewildered, and runs hither and thither, just as it happened to Venerable Meghiya. They run from this side to that side, driven by these thoughts inside the mind. As you, dear practitioners, know, although the physical body might not move back and forth according to the thoughts in the mind, it is as if one is running hither and thither. Just as we see an ordinary animal running here and there in accordance with its thoughts, a person with a distracted mind falls into such a restless state. Thus, referring to the person who cannot tame their thoughts, the verse describes this, and the next verse shows:

Ete ca vidvā manaso vitakke,

ātāpiyo saṃvaratī satīmā;

Anugate manaso uppilāve,

asesam'ete pajahāsi buddho.

Here, next, he declared regarding himself. Recognizing this kind of thoughts, this host of thoughts—*ete ca vidvā manaso vitakke, ātāpiyo saṃvaratī satīmā*—the Buddha, or the wise person, what does he do? *ātāpī* means, with defilement-burning energy and mindfulness (*sati*), he restrains them. He restrains these thoughts. He tames them. Here, what was declared by way of this joyful utterance (*udāna gāthā*) is that the Buddha is entirely free from all such thoughts arising in the mind.

What was the mistake made by Venerable Meghiya? Now we can understand that Venerable Meghiya went for a good purpose—for intense striving (*padhāna-viriya*). That is why the Buddha finally said, "If you say so, what can we say? Then go." But he went before the right time had arrived. He was too hasty. That is what we must consider. Meditation is a good idea, but Venerable Meghiya was too hasty. Moreover, he committed a serious mistake: disobeying the words of the Buddha. He made that request for the third time. That is a grave action, almost like an antagonistic karma (*āṇāticchevaka* / acts of defiance). Its very consequence is enough to make the mind restless. It is that serious. Coming as an attendant, forgetting his duties of service, forgetting his duties toward the Buddha, and ignoring the advice, he went to meditate in that manner. It was a grand idea, but he was not ready for the task. The mind was not yet prepared.

Now, even if one is given a car to drive, or buys a new car, if one does not know how to drive it, one goes around with an 'L' board for a while, keeping another person beside them. Similarly, this monk was a person who should have taken instructions from the Buddha and proceeded at the proper time. But he was hasty, also due to pride and conceit (*māna*). That is why he even uttered words like, "The Buddha has finished his work, but I have not." So, to address this, the Buddha delivered the verses we took as our theme earlier, revealing the nature of the mind, the character of a mind.

Phandanam capalam cittam

durakkham dunnivārayam

ujum karoti medhāvi

usukāro'va tejanam

It comes with an excellent simile. As you, dear practitioners, know, in these Dhammapada verses—and this too is a verse from the Citta Vagga—the Buddha gives wonderful similes. Here, describing the nature of this mind: "*Phandanam capalam cittam - durakkham dunnivārayam*." This mind—*phandanam* means it trembles or wavers. This is explained as the trembling nature of the mind in an ordinary *saṃsāric* being in the presence of sense objects like forms and sounds. That mind wavers—*phandanam*—and *capalam*, it is also fickle. Now, Venerable Meghiya went with the intention of realizing Nibbāna, yet the mind was fickle. Ultimately, it was overcome even by thoughts of sensual desire. This is the nature of the mind; there is nothing strange about it. This is a condition to be expected. Why? Because a mind that has run for so long in the circular track of *saṃsāra* cannot be pulled out of it all of a sudden. That *saṃsāric* momentum is still active. A quite powerful momentum must arise from within to counter it. That is where those five factors, such as association with a teacher, help. So—*phandanam capalam*—this mind is fickle. You know what "fickle" means; there is no need to explain it anew. It does not refer merely to being fickle in speech. We often use "fickle" (*capala*) regarding words, but here "fickle" means the mind does something else other than what it set out to do. That is why it is said, "Wavering, fickle is the mind."

"*Durakkham*" means, just as it is difficult to guard ripening paddy from cattle, similarly, it is difficult to guard the object of meditation (*kammaṭṭhāna*), to maintain the mind on the object of meditation—"*durakkham*"—in short, this mind is difficult to guard. Likewise, "*dunnivārayam*" means it is difficult to restrain the mind from wandering to unwholesome objects. The mind is difficult to guard. When it tries to break free and burst out, restraining it is not easy. That

is the condition of the mind. Declaring the truth as it is, is the characteristic feature of the Buddha's Dhamma teachings. Thus, these weaknesses of the mind are to be expected. "**Ujum karoti medhāvī**"—but what does the wise person, the intelligent one, do? He straightens the crooked, bent, and fickle mind. How? Here is the simile: "**usukāro'va tejanam**"—just as a fletcher straightens an arrow. Straightening an arrow: let us imagine bringing a suitable piece of wood with good core from the forest, cleaning it, and then, if it is bent, straightening it by heating it over fire or using some other method, then oiling it, seasoning it, and sharpening it well to make an arrow. Once the arrow is made, it is so strong and performs such a great task that a skilled archer can split a horsehair at a distance by the flash of lightning. You have heard this simile: "To shoot a horsehair in the dark from afar—if the flash of lightning is missed, the shot goes wrong." Realizing Nibbāna is a similar thing. What is meant there is sharpening the power of wisdom (**paññā**) to realize Nibbāna. All of this is done through the mind. Just as a fletcher seasons, straightens, and sharpens an arrow with systematic effort, the wise person straightens his mind—this mind with such weaknesses—so it is declared.

Vārijo'va thale khitto

okamokata-ubbhato

pariphandat'idam cittam

māradheyyam pahātave

Here too, a simile is given. Water is the home of the fish. Just as a fish taken out from that home of water and thrown onto the dry land flutters this way and that, when one tries to depart from the familiar realm of Māra, this mind trembles this way and that, just 'like a fish drawn from water'. Thus, the Buddha has shown the state of the mind in these two verses.

Therefore, this is a highly valuable Sutta sermon for us in several ways. Now, with the help of that story, we can gather what is lacking. Here, we have shown the general meaning of the verses. Even if we think about the story, as we mentioned earlier, the intention of a meditating practitioner (**yogāvacara**) to realize Nibbāna is good. That desire is good. Yet, the mind must be prepared in a manner suitable for it—for this, desire (**chanda**), meaning a strong desire, is required. First of all, the primary factor is receiving guidance. That is why association with a spiritual friend (**kalyāṇa-mitta**) is necessary. Next, there must be a powerful desire—what is called **chanda**. A person must truly arouse a powerful desire within themselves. Now, Venerable Meghiya thought that simply because he ordained with the intention of realizing Nibbāna, or with great faith

(*saddhā*), these defilements would not flood his mind. Thinking so, he fell into that state of urgency (*saṃvega*). But this is a natural law (*dhammatā*).

Let us think of it in terms of a vehicle, as we did before. When a car is parked in a garage, it does not meet with accidents. A car in a garage never experiences things like road accidents. It is only from the moment it is taken out onto the road that it has to face accidents. Similarly, as long as the practitioner (*yogāvacara*) is merely thinking about meditating, there is no danger. It is on the day they actually plunge into it and go into seclusion that the oppressions of Māra arrive. That is the situation. It is to be expected. The Buddha advises us to go prepared for this. In that way, there must be association with a teacher. One must follow instructions with respect. Next, there must be a powerful desire (*chanda*). Next, one must be complete in virtue (*sīla*). If one is not virtuous, regrets arise. When one goes and sits down, thoughts about regrets flood in: "Alas, I have done such and such, haven't I?"

Now, you, dear practitioners, know. A person who meditates, who strives to bring the mind to concentration (*samādhi*), must know about the five hindrances (*nīvaraṇa*) that obstruct that concentration, in some way or another—whether by name or in general. If we translate the terms *kāmachanda, byāpāda, thīna-middha, uddhacca-kukkucca, vicikicchā* into plain language, they are: thoughts regarding sensual desires, or sensual thoughts; next, thoughts of ill-will; next, sleepiness and sluggishness; next, restlessness and regret (*uddhacca-kukkucca*), where restlessness means restless thoughts about the future, and regret means regret over things done or said in the past (these two are shown as one hindrance); and doubt (*vicikicchā*), which is indecision—thinking, "Will this work or not?" Freeing the mind from these factors is how one makes the mind still. Concentration (*samādhi*) means stillness.

Now, the aforementioned factors help to eliminate these hindrances. If one's virtue (*sīla*), especially virtue, is impure, then doubts and regrets arise in that person in that manner. Thoughts about one's past come flooding: "I have done such and such, haven't I?" Therefore, one must be endowed with virtue (*sīla*). Next, by hearing the ten subjects of talk (*dasa-kathāvatthu*), just as one gains some understanding regarding Nibbāna and the path of progress, one must also gain some understanding regarding the qualities to be practiced through them—such as wanting little (*appicchatā*), contentment (*santuṭṭhitā*), etc.—and train accordingly. Next, aroused energy (*ārabdha-viriya*) means one must proceed with determination, having intense energy, relentless energy. Next, one must be a person of wisdom (*paññā*)—an intelligent, wise person. Ignoring all such matters, and especially showing no regard for serving the Buddha, one cannot

succeed in meditation by proceeding in that way. No progress can be expected when one turns their back on the advice of the teacher.

So, we can take a great deal of instruction from that story. Next are these other matters. Let us think about the four meditations mentioned. If we contemplate them, we can see that the way the Buddha presents these four meditations here is highly systematic. Often, the Buddha's teachings—not just often, but always—in fact, the best way to determine whether a teaching is truly the Buddha's or not, is to see how these factors fit together. They fit together in such a wonderful manner: the first leads to the second, the second to the third, the third to the fourth, the fourth to the fifth, and so on. Here too, when showing them as meditations, he shows at the very outset: the strongest **saṃsāric** habit in a **saṃsāric** being—as you all know—is attachment, lust (**rāga**). In whatever way one takes it, whether subtle or coarse, strong attachments are the very nature of **saṃsāra**. What is called craving / thirst (**taṇhā**) is, in another sense, this very same thing. Therefore, the remedy for it is foulness (**asubha**). Especially, this attachment arises because of the lust towards one's own body. Thus, what is done by developing foulness is understanding the foul nature of the body. Whichever object of meditation (**kammaṭṭhāna**) is used—whether something from the thirty-two parts of the body such as hair of the head, hair of the body, nails, teeth, etc., or something regarding a bloated corpse, etc.—this reflecting on the foulness of the body is called the perception of foulness (**asubha-saññā**). That perception of foulness must be developed for the abandoning of lust (**rāga**). Next, just as on one side there is attachment, on the other side there is aversion (**paṭigha** / collision / friction)—often arising because attachment is not fulfilled—which is a serious weakness of the mind. The remedy for it is the meditation on loving-kindness (**mettā**). This, dear practitioners, you can understand very easily.

Now, next—this is all about preparing the mind. It is between these two [attachment and aversion] that the mind chiefly becomes crooked, bent, and fickle. But the matter does not end there. Generally, we speak of the five cords of sensual pleasure (**pañca-kāmaḡaṇa**). These are the objects coming through the five external senses—eye, ear, nose, tongue, and body. Ordinary people think that it is because of these that our minds are disturbed. Therefore, some think: "If I close myself off from these, close my ears, and close my eyes as much as possible, and go to a secluded place, I will be able to realize Nibbāna." This is a wrong idea. Why? Because all the objects taken in through these five senses accumulate in the mind. As you, dear practitioners, know, just as various machines are invented in this day and age, our **viññāṇa** (Consciousness) is also like that. All those many **saṃsāric** habits acquired in the past **saṃsāra** are deposited in this **viññāṇa** (Consciousness)—attachments and aversions. Similarly, the objects taken in from

those five senses are deposited in the mind in some way. Sitting around, these five [senses], like messengers, bring everything and deposit them in the mind. Then, those deposited things surface precisely when one sits down alone in silence. No form comes to the eye, no sound comes to the ear; one is protected from all of them. Yet, they arise from within the mind itself. Due to *saṃsāric* tendencies, and in accordance with one's karma, various defiled thoughts (*vitakka*) surface through this *viññāṇa* (Consciousness). It was to these that Venerable Meghiya succumbed. That is the situation. The remedy the Buddha gives for that is mindfulness of breathing (*ānāpānasati*).

Mindfulness of breathing (*ānāpānasati*) is an extremely subtle meditation. If we describe it with a simile—there are indeed numerous meditation subjects, but the meditation on mindfulness of breathing is the royal road. We can say it is like the royal road. Why? Because every Buddha attained Buddhahood through the meditation on mindfulness of breathing. If you think about it, you will realize that once the mind is calmed through other auxiliary meditations like foulness or loving-kindness, mindfulness (*sati*) naturally establishes itself on one's inhalation and exhalation. Mindfulness of breathing (*ānāpānasati*) means mindfulness regarding inhalation and exhalation. Usually, people do not apply mindfulness to this. Most people do not even remember that they are breathing. They think of this as a machine that operates eternally. Ordinary people also forget that everything depends on this life-breath beneath it. But in that manner, when these two grave defilements, lust (*rāga*) and hatred (*dosa*), are subdued by the meditation on foulness and loving-kindness, then mindfulness of breathing becomes very easy. However, mindfulness of breathing is mentioned here as being for the purpose of cutting off thoughts. Some practitioners (*yogāvacara*) say, "Even though the Buddha said this is for cutting off thoughts, it is when I sit down for mindfulness of breathing that thoughts start flooding in." That is nothing to be surprised about. Sometimes, a disease only surfaces when one begins to treat it. It is the disease inside. So, one must be prepared to face it, and the necessary medicine must be at hand. That is the kind of situation we have in mindfulness of breathing. It is not that the disease was absent; the existing disease surfaced. Some physicians do exactly that. To bring out the disease, they first give a strong purgative mixture. Having given something to bring the disease out, they then administer the required medicinal elixir. Similarly, it purges in that manner. But indeed, then the host of thoughts arrives. The host of thoughts arrives. How powerful it is can be seen from how this monk must have tried the entire evening, sitting under that beautiful, delightful mango tree—sitting properly in the cross-legged posture—yet he could not unify his mind. Only when it was impossible did he go back. So powerful is the momentum of these thoughts. That is the most wonderful thing. What oppresses the world is this host

of thoughts. This comes from within the mind in accordance with karma and the character of each individual. Mindfulness of breathing helps to cut these off. Through mindfulness of breathing, those are understood at various levels. Only when the disease surfaces at its various levels can the remedies be applied. Thus, when the mind finally scatters through these thoughts arising from within, an understanding comes to that person.

Now, let us take the perception of the impermanent / inconstant (*anicca-saññā*). Let us also understand why the Buddha, fourthly, speaks of the perception of the impermanent / inconstant (*anicca-saññā*). This is a somewhat deep idea. If you, dear practitioners, have understood this: having applied remedies for lust and hatred, the disease was brought out through mindfulness of breathing. That is, thoughts (*vitakka*). Now it is a battle with thoughts. What are thoughts? The objects taken in through those five senses throughout this *saṃsāra* up to now, and in this life—whether today, yesterday, or in the past—are deposited in this mind. They surface and trouble the meditator. So, when they surface, this person has to battle with them. That is why it was said, "*ātāpiyo saṃvaratī satimā*."

In those initial verses preached by the Buddha, it was expressed as "*khuddā vitakkā sukhumā vitakkā anugatā manaso uppilāvā*"—minor thoughts, extremely small things, not grand things. Sometimes, a word spoken by someone years ago, which might lead to hatred. Or a form barely seen somewhere years ago; thoughts arise based on this. They crash in so forcefully that one cannot remove them. A practitioner (*yogāvacara*) gets to experience such conditions. In those instances, one sees how serious an obstacle these thoughts are to meditation. One must be strong to cut them off. Thus, those minor thoughts, subtle thoughts, come from within the mind itself and float on the mind, stirring it up. How does one restrain these? "*ātāpiyo*"—with defilement-burning energy, not giving way. What helps in this is the object of meditation (*kammaṭṭhāna*).

Now, you, dear practitioners, know—during the time paddy is ripening, a person ties a bull to prevent it from being attracted to the paddy. That bull also tries as much as possible to reach the paddy. But it cannot, and it is pulled back. Finally, when it can do nothing else, it lies down near the post. Similarly, that is the value of tying the mind to an object of meditation (*kammaṭṭhāna*). It is in relation to some object of meditation—only when one holds onto an object of meditation—that one can gain the awareness that the mind is wandering away from it. Some people think that merely watching how the mind wanders is enough to make it still. That does not work. You can never do this by running along with a wild bull. Instead, what must be done is to give it an object of meditation, to tie it to a post. Once it is tied, every time it pulls, with defilement-burning energy and

mindfulness—mindfulness (*sati*) helps there—applying the two terms *sati-sampajañña*, which are mindfulness and clear comprehension, very rapidly and as quickly as possible according to the situation, it is brought back near the post. If you let it go, you will, without even knowing it, end up in a state where you do not even know where you are. Such is the nature of thoughts (*vitakka*).

That is why, as you, dear practitioners, know, to anyone who has a general understanding of the nature of the mind, some object makes contact (*phassa*). It touches. Accordingly, a sensation / feeling (*vedanā*) arises. That sensation / feeling (*vedanā*) can be a pleasant sensation or an unpleasant sensation. Neutral sensation is almost imperceptible; regarding it, it is called ordinary equanimity (*upekkhā*)—mostly ignorant equanimity—but mostly it is pleasant sensation or unpleasant sensation. In accordance with these two, next, one takes a perception (*saññā*). One takes a perception, as good or bad. It is upon that perception (*saññā*) that thoughts (*vitakka*) are built up. Once one succumbs to those thoughts, something happens. That can be called conceptual proliferation / prolific conceptualization (*papañca*). Conceptual proliferation / prolific conceptualization (*papañca*) means that because of those thoughts, due to their branching out, one finally falls into a wonderful state of delusion. One falls into a grave delusion. Within thoughts themselves, one wanders this way and that. Running to the past and the future, to the extent that one does not even know where one is. These stages are shown in the Dhamma: "*yaṃ vedeti taṃ sañjānāti*"—what one feels, that one perceives; "*yaṃ sañjānāti taṃ vitakketi*"—what one perceives, that one thinks about; "*yaṃ vitakketi taṃ papañceti*"—what one thinks about, that one conceptually proliferates (*papañca*). Overwhelmed by a massive tangle of thoughts for which one cannot find beginning or end, one is finally overwhelmed by the very thoughts one created, and forgets the very purpose for which one came. The mind is distracted in that manner.

Why does all this happen? It is because of unwise attention (*ayoniso-manasikāra*). It is there that the meaning of the word *Yoniso manasikāra* (Wise attention) declared by the Buddha becomes important. Now, everyone in the world knows about reflection, about attention (*manasikāra*). Our minds have the ability to reflect. We reflect on something. We bring it to mind, to the thoughts. Ordinary people practice this reflection in an unwise way (*ayoniso*). In some old books, it is translated as "unwisely" or ignorantly. In modern terms, we can explain it as "inappropriate reflection," ignorant reflection. It is incorrect reflection, in a way that gives room to defilements. *Yoniso manasikāra* (Wise attention) means reflecting with wisdom. If we think about it more deeply, *yoniso* means directing the mind to the very root where a thought, an idea, arises—directing the mind to the very cause from which a disease originates—and

reflecting. That is the reflection a meditating yogi must practice: *Yoniso manasikāra* (Wise attention). Here too, it is the same. Without letting it go further—when contact (*phassa*) occurs, without letting it go further—as soon as one gives room to sensation / feeling (*vedanā*), next, perceptions (*saññā*) arise in accordance with it. As soon as perceptions arise, in accordance with those perceptions, thoughts—ideations—are built up in the mind. Succumbing to those thoughts is what is called conceptual proliferation / prolific conceptualization (*papañca*).

Such a state exists in this world. It is within this that the entire *saṃsāra* is found. It is within these thoughts; it is by the mind itself that this *saṃsāra* is created, and it is by the mind itself that one is freed from *saṃsāra*. Thus, with reference to this, we can contemplate the perception of the impermanent / inconstant (*anicca-saññā*) given by the Buddha. Indeed, the perception of the impermanent / inconstant (*anicca-saññā*) can be understood by everyone in the ordinary world. We all see this perception of the impermanent / inconstant in daily life: look, something that existed has decayed. That is its coarse, gross aspect. In the deepest aspect of the perception of the impermanent / inconstant (*anicca-saññā*), it arises by seeing the impermanent / inconstant (*anicca*) nature of thoughts. These thoughts—even what we took as "my thoughts," do they not scatter in this manner? Or, one gains some understanding regarding this scattering nature, that this mind scatters due to the influence of past defilements—precisely through that training. That training is practiced. The training is practiced to make the mind still through concentration (*samādhi*). Yet, what is understood by the stilled mind—understood in accordance with reality (*yathābhūta*)—is the nature of this mind. This is not a single mind; there is nothing to be called "I" here. Different thoughts arise at each moment. These thoughts exist for a moment. The understanding arises that it is because we tightly hold onto this by way of grasping / holding / fuel (*upādāna*) that an entire *saṃsāra* is created, an existence / becoming (*bhava*) is brought about. That is what the Buddha declared: in one who has the perception of the impermanent / inconstant (*anicca-saññā*), the perception of not-self / non-self / unsubstantial (*anattā*) becomes established. He who has the perception of not-self / non-self / unsubstantial (*anattā*) removes this conceit "I am" (*asmimāna*)—this subtle conceit "I am"—and right in this life is cooled by the noble, supreme Nibbāna; that is why it was so declared. Because, due to that distracted, scattering nature of the mind, the understanding arises that there is nothing here to be taken as "myself," there is no such thing as a self here. These thoughts arise. While deleting them as they arise, like deleting characters here and there, the understanding comes to oneself that there is nothing here to be grabbed as "myself," nothing to be taken as "mine." Now, the thought grabbed as

"myself" ends in another moment. It disappears. That is understood when *sati-sampajañña*, which is mindfulness and clear comprehension—mindfulness and wisdom—is well applied.

Indeed, that too is a concentration (*samādhi*). Why? Because on one occasion, when showing four developments of concentration (*samādhi-bhāvanā*)—let us speak only of the relevant one—the Buddha says, "Monks, there is a development of concentration that leads to the development of mindfulness and clear comprehension (*sati-sampajañña*)." What is that development of concentration? It is shown thus: here, for a monk, sensations / feelings (*vedanā*) arise known. They persist known. They pass away known. Likewise, perceptions (*saññā*) arise known. They persist known. They pass away known. Likewise, thoughts (*vitakka* / ideations) arise known. They persist known. They pass away known. What is the natural law (*dhammatā*) found in this? It comes down to those three words: arising, persisting, and passing away—arising, persisting, passing away. If we take it briefly, there is only arising and passing away. But what is called "persisting" is indeed that grasping / holding / fuel (*upādāna*)—the holding on. In that instance, within that, it "persists." Within that, a "person" persists. So, that is all there is in the world: arising, persisting, passing away. This is realized very deeply—now, the difference between arising and passing away in the material world is difficult for many to understand. Their decay is not understood in the ordinary world. It is only on the day it is thrown away, on the day it is thrown onto a garbage pile, thinking "this is of no use now, this is finished, no use can be made of it," that it is discarded. But in the material world, that arising and passing away, or impermanence / inconstancy (*anicca*), is at a highly gross, coarse level. This impermanence / inconstancy (*anicca*) is understood in a subtle way precisely by seeing these thoughts in that manner—arising, persisting, and passing away. It begins to be understood by one's mind stilled through defilement-burning effort (*ātāpa*).

In that meditation, the effort is to keep mindfulness (*sati*) established on the breath. Yet, in the meantime, those thoughts come. Those thoughts taken in from the past or various things come. One has to subdue them too. It is through the understanding that "this is the condition of this mind" that one finally realizes that there is nothing to be taken as a self even in this *viññāṇa* (Consciousness). That there is no self (*anattā*) in form (*rūpa*) can generally be understood easily when it decays. Sensation / feeling (*vedanā*) too—one sensation comes, another sensation comes—can also be understood with a bit more difficulty. Perception (*saññā*) is also understood with a bit more difficulty. The impermanence / inconstancy (*anicca*) regarding *Saṅkhāra* (Formations), which are intentions, is also understood with some difficulty. But *viññāṇa* (Consciousness) is the grand illusion, the greatest illusion of beings in this world.

The Buddha also compared this *viññāṇa* (Consciousness) to an illusion. That is something one must experience for oneself. The path to that is what the Buddha has shown here by systematically presenting the meditation subjects.

Therefore, with reference to that, you, dear practitioners, can also understand that for a person who hopes for this life of a practitioner (*yogāvacara*), who hopes to plunge into this, it is wrong to think of this as an easy task. If one thinks of this as easy, they will soon get disappointed with it. Knowing that this is a difficult task, preparing the mind for it, and developing great energy, one must plunge into this work. Otherwise, what do they do? Either they blame the teacher, or they blame the meditation. Now, just because a road accident occurs, does a person stop driving? No. There can be various reasons for that road accident. Sometimes, it could be the ignorance of the driver. Similarly, because some people suffer mental stress and various afflictions through meditation, some in this day and age think of meditation as an easy way to get the mind distracted. That is a wrong idea. It is the hasty ones, like Venerable Meghiya, who do so, think so, and fall into such a state.

The wise person remembers those instructions given by the Buddha. We must enter upon this task having prepared the mind. What helps in this, principally, is the association with a teacher. The Buddha, as we expressed earlier, is the incomparable spiritual friend (*kalyāṇa-mitta*) of the world. Then, after the demise of the Buddha, or even during the time he was living, the great Arahants headed by Venerable Sāriputta, like parents to children, helped to guide disciples up to the state of Arahantship, just like the Buddha. Next, the eighty chief disciples. Next, the other monks of the Saṅgha according to their respective capacities. Next, after their demise, as long as this Dispensation of the Buddha (*Buddha-sāsana*) exists, whether lay or ordained, if some person has traveled on this path of meditation and achieved some progress, having an understanding of these matters, that person indeed is the spiritual friend (*kalyāṇa-mitta*), the teacher. Obeying their word, one must be ready to take steps according to the situation. For that, humility is required.

Next, other factors are strengthening the mind through virtue (*sīla*), hearing the Dhamma, etc., developing a powerful desire (*chanda*), an aspiration, and next, exerting energy, applying the mind intelligently and wisely—wisdom (*paññā*). These kinds of factors help. The same goes for the said path of meditation. Without mixing them up, without causing confusion, one must enter that path of meditation. One should not do last what should be done first, and one should not do first what should be done last. Some people jump into mindfulness of breathing (*ānāpānasati*), thinking it is a highly valuable meditation. But they are not prepared for it. So, they next blame the practice:

"Even though the Buddha told us to practice mindfulness of breathing to cut off thoughts, as for me, when I go to practice this, it is thoughts themselves that come!" In this way, some even blame the Buddha's teaching.

What is the reason for this? It is that coarse level mentioned earlier. Now, you, dear practitioners, know how a carpenter uses a plane. Think about it. First, he uses it to cut away the coarse parts of the wood. Having done that, by tapping the plane or taking a different plane, he next shaves a little more. After that, he takes a finer plane. A similar thing applies to this mind. There are coarse levels and subtle levels of the mind; so, coarse levels are eliminated by coarse means. That helps. Some say—there is an opinion that the meditation on foulness (*asubha-bhāvanā*) is not good for laypeople. Whether lay or ordained, if one hopes for Nibbāna, this is helpful. Even if we think about this society, and the defilements of lust (*rāga*), etc., if we think about laypeople, how many crimes are committed because of attachment to these? If there is some restraint and control regarding these, even society would reach a more peaceful state. Even in a home, in a household, there would be control and restraint. The same applies to the other: ill-will (*byāpāda*). Thus, the world mostly lives within these two—attachments and aversions. But after subduing them, there is further to go. It is from there onward that the simile of the subtle plane applies. That is what must be taken there. The Buddha has declared: "*khuddā vitakkā sukhumā vitakkā*" (minor thoughts, subtle thoughts).

Just by seeing a good mango grove, thinking "If I go there and meditate, I will be able to attain Nibbāna all at once; what the Buddha strove for so long to achieve, I can do in a single evening"—with this thought, Venerable Meghiya went. But although everything else was fine—the mango grove was highly delightful, there was good shade and a good seat, everything was perfect—still, he could not tame his mind. Why? Because from beneath, those thoughts arose. All that trash, just like a stream carrying all the garbage when it flows after a heavy rain. A practitioner (*yogāvacara*) striving for Nibbāna even has to face such situations.

In such moments, one should not get discouraged. This is something to be expected. That trash must flow out from somewhere. Now, you, dear practitioners, know what happens after taking a purgative mixture—there is no need to explain details to you about that. So, after taking a purgative, look, one thinks, "Alas, is this the reality? Isn't this the reality of the body I took to be mine? Isn't this the reality of food?" In those moments, it becomes clearly apparent. Similarly, after sitting down for mindfulness of breathing (*ānāpānasati*), having fulfilled those initial factors, then comes the stream of trash from within this mind. Yet, through that, training is also achieved. Through training, understanding also comes. This is something difficult to tame. But why

do we tame it? To sharpen this understanding. This is the Middle Path (*majjhimā paṭipadā*). A highly deep matter is being discussed here. In truth, this is unparalleled. The solution to the problem, the question, of escaping from this *saṃsāra*, which no other teacher in the world could solve, was presented by the Buddha through the Middle Path.

A certain stilling of the mind is fundamentally necessary. Unifying the mind is also necessary. Although we say "unifying," this is not a single entity. At the moment of unifying the mind, its scattering nature is understood. It scatters moment by moment. Due to habits, etc., coming from various character traits shown as past karma, character, tendencies, and virtues, various kinds of thoughts (*vitakka*) arise. One does not get discouraged by them. But ultimately, what is done through that? Next, one sees: "There is nothing here to be held onto. Where there is holding on, there is Māra. Where there is holding on, 'I' am there. Where there is holding on, all these troubles are there." One sees the truth as it is, in accordance with reality (*yathābhūta*). All this is impermanent / inconstant (*anicca*). Whatever is impermanent / inconstant (*anicca*) is suffering (*dukkha* / unsatisfactoriness / stress). Because one holds onto what is impermanent / inconstant (*anicca*), one falls into suffering / unsatisfactoriness / stress (*dukkha*). Similarly, the understanding arises that "nothing here can be maintained under my control as 'myself' or 'mine'." When that understanding arises, when it arises very deeply, that is when a person removes that final tumor called "the conceit 'I am'" (*asmimāna*), as declared by the Buddha. It is through the tumor called "I am" (*asmi*) that this entire world is projected.

Now, "I" is generally a gross, coarse feeling. That is what is called the dogma of self-illusion (*sakkāya-diṭṭhi*). The work is not finished merely by eliminating the view "I" and "mine." The most subtle level is "am-ness" (*asmi*). It is not even "I am"—it is "am-ness." That lies deposited in the mind in a highly subtle manner. That can be properly seen only when the scattering nature of the mind is correctly realized, at the very point where that holding on is let go. At the point of holding on—now, when contact (*phassa*) occurs, it is through holding onto it that sensation / feeling (*vedanā*) arises. When it is held onto there, it turns into perception (*saññā*). Perception turns into thought (*vitakka*). Having turned into thought, the point where the thought is held onto is conceptual proliferation / prolific conceptualization (*papañca*). From there onward, the mind finally ends up in a state like an asylum. To prevent that, one must abandon that incorrect method called unwise attention (*ayoniso-manasikāra*). The battle is not to be started from the other end. This battle must be started as the Buddha declared in the first verse of the Dhammapada:

"Mind precedes all phenomena, mind is chief, mind-made are they."

The understanding that everything arises from the mind itself in this manner emerges clearly in the deep stages of that meditation.

Therefore, you, dear practitioners, must reflect. On this present Poya day, we should not arouse faith (*saddhā*) merely by thinking about the life of the Buddha. The one who truly knows the Buddha is the one who has actually realized Nibbāna. Otherwise, we only see some forms, or a Buddha created by our thoughts. Therefore, if we hope to see the Buddha, if we hope to know him, we must travel on the path to Nibbāna. We must understand this truth that has been declared. Only then can the Buddha be truly seen. Only then does faith (*saddhā*) in the Buddha become complete.

Therefore, on this valuable day, through this hearing of the Dhamma, certain matters related to those ten subjects of talk mentioned earlier would have been spoken to you. It is still possible to benefit from this Dispensation (*sāsana*) in this very life. Some think of this as something outdated. But the very same fires that burned during the Buddha's time are burning now—the fires of lust, hatred, and delusion. So, the extinguishing of the fires is what is called Nibbāna. It is nothing else; it is not some strange world, not some place like a celestial realm. Some think so. It is extinguishment. Therefore, what is found in *saṃsāra* is burning. In place of that, the Buddha presents extinguishment. What is found in *saṃsāra* is existence / becoming (*bhava* / continuation). Understanding that this existence / becoming is suffering / unsatisfactoriness / stress (*dukkha*), and bringing about its cooling—that is what we called escaping from the circular track of *saṃsāra*. Spinning in the circular track of *saṃsāra* is faring on (*saṃsaraṇa*). Escaping from it is escape (*nissaraṇa*). Escaping from the kingdom of Māra is what is called Nibbāna—from the perspective of defilements!

Therefore, taking that state as the goal of one's life, in this rare human existence during this rare period of a Buddha's appearance, in this final phase of the Dispensation—perhaps after a few generations, a situation will arise where one cannot truly benefit from this Dhamma. Why? Because association with a teacher will be lost. Those who are engaged in these practices and can give instructions on this path to Nibbāna will not be found. Earlier, it was still easy to find them. That will become impossible. For that very reason, you, dear practitioners, should diligently, keeping in mind the Buddha's exhortation on diligence, make a firm determination to walk on this path to Nibbāna.

You should not think that the few wholesome qualities that arose in your minds through listening to this Dhamma sermon up to now are insignificant. Specifically, faith (*saddhā*), energy (*viriya*), mindfulness (*sati*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*) are listed among the thirty-

seven factors of enlightenment (*bodhipakkhiya-dhamma*). They perform dual functions as spiritual faculties (*indriya*) and spiritual powers (*bala*). Faith (*saddhā*) is a faculty as well as a power; it is a quality that can demonstrate capability as well as powerful action. Likewise, energy (*viriya*) is the energy that follows faith. Next, through the energy applied to burn away defilements and draw near wholesome qualities, mindfulness (*sati*) arises—mindfulness, awareness. The very state of maintaining mindfulness for a long time becomes concentration (*samādhi*). Finally, mindfulness overflows and turns into concentration. To the concentrated mind, the seeing of things as they truly are in accordance with reality (*yathābhūta*)—wisdom (*paññā*)—arises. Indeed, these [faculties of] faith, energy, mindfulness, concentration, and wisdom operate as spiritual faculties and spiritual powers precisely when one correctly plunges into the meditation for realizing Nibbāna.

But even to arouse them at a minor level—according to your capacity to apply yourselves to meditation—I hope this Dhamma sermon has been of help. May you make the aspiration: "By the power of having aroused those qualities of faith (*saddhā*), energy (*viriya*), mindfulness (*sati*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*) through listening to such a sermon, striving as much as possible in this very life, may we have the strength and power to escape from this entire *saṃsāric* suffering / unsatisfactoriness / stress (*dukkha*) through the penetration of the paths and fruits of Stream-entry (*Sotāpatti*), Once-returning (*Sakadāgāmitā*), Non-returning (*Anāgāmitā*), and Arahantship, and be cooled by the noble, supreme Nibbāna!" Likewise, may all those who expect to share in our merits—from the deepest Avīci hell up to the highest Akanitṭha heaven, including the guardian deities of the Dispensation and one's own departed relatives—rejoice in this store of merit we have accumulated through the preaching and hearing of the Dhamma. Having rejoiced, and having found association with spiritual friends (*kalyāṇa-mitta*), may they be freed from all *saṃsāric* suffering / unsatisfactoriness / stress (*dukkha*) as quickly as possible and be cooled by the noble, supreme Nibbāna! With this aspiration, next, dedicate the merits by reciting these verses:

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”